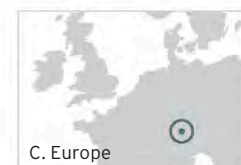


Neuschwanstein Castle

A fairy-tale castle from a Wagnerian fantasy created by King Ludwig of Bavaria at a spectacular clifftop location



Neuschwanstein is famously known as the model for the Sleeping Beauty Castle in Disneyland, California. It was an apt choice because the German castle, situated on a rocky outcrop in southern Bavaria, is a romantic wonderland in its own right. It is a theatrical tour de force that looks like a medieval castle, although it was built in the 19th century. It has a Minstrels' Hall, where musicians never performed, and a Throne Room, where no throne was ever installed.

Medieval fantasy

Neuschwanstein was the creation of Ludwig II, King of Bavaria (r.1864–1886). He had a difficult childhood and developed a fixation with medieval history. In particular, he became fascinated by Lohengrin, a figure from Arthurian literature. Ludwig decided to create a Grail Castle, where the Holy Grail was reputedly kept in Arthurian lore, and hired Christian Jank, a scene-painter who had helped to stage the dramatist and composer Richard Wagner's opera *Lohengrin*, to design his ambitious project.

Sadly, Ludwig did not live to see his dream completed. He was deposed by the Bavarian authorities and died under mysterious circumstances. During World War II, Neuschwanstein was used as a storehouse for Nazi loot. Since then, it has become a hugely popular tourist destination.

CONSERVATION EFFORTS

Ludwig's Castle is constructed in a dramatic setting. However, its sheer rock walls and foundations are closely monitored and secured periodically. The limestone facades are also prone to weathering.

A MODERN BUILD

Despite its appearance, the castle is a thoroughly 19th-century building that sits on concrete foundations and is made of limestone-clad brick. The structure is 427 ft (130 m) long, and its highest tower reaches 213 ft (65 m) into the sky. More than 200 rooms over six floors were planned, but only 14 were completed, including the Byzantine-style Throne Room, which features a gilded cupola.

